GUARDIAN

Quick Start: How to Play

A tactical card game for two. Command a Guardian, march your Summons across the grid, and bring the enemy Guardian to its knees.



For the digital client · Alpha, October 2026 · Covers the basics for your first games

CHAPTER 1

1 The goal, and what you play with

Guardian mixes a collectible card game with a tactics game like Fire Emblem. You play cards from your hand, but your units fight on a grid, so **where** they stand matters as much as how strong they are.

How you win

- Bring the enemy **Guardian from 15 Life to 0**, or
- your opponent has to **draw from an empty deck**.

A few cards add their own ways to win, and say so on the card.

Your Guardian

Your champion. It starts in play in your Guardian Zone and never goes into your deck. It has **15 Life**, and every turn it gives you **1 Neutral Energy**.

Most Guardians also have a passive ability and an activated one, printed on the card. Your Guardian can strike back too: see *Combat*.

Your cards

- **Main Deck**: at least 55 cards.
- **Treasure Chest**: 5 extra cards, kept face down beside your deck (at least 4 of them Treasures). You can buy cards out of it during the game; see *Energy*.

Starting a game

- Each player draws **6 cards**, and may shuffle back any of them and redraw once (a mulligan).
- The player who goes first skips straight to the main phase on turn 1. They don't draw and don't get their Guardian's Energy that turn.



A Guardian card: Talas, Defender of the Meek. 15 Life, Attack 3.

Your first game in the client

- **Solo Play → Campaign** starts small and introduces the rules a few at a time.
- **Solo Play → Bot Play**: pick one of the **Starter Decks** and play the computer.
- **Online Play** once you're ready for a friend.

CHAPTER 2

2 The board

A grid of 5 columns. Each player owns three rows; your Guardian sits behind your back row. Summons stand on the fields, one per field.



Guarded Zone	Your back row, right in front of your Guardian. New Summons arrive here. An enemy that gets in here can attack your Guardian.
Battle Zone 1	Your middle row.
Battle Zone 2	Your front row, at the Front.
The Front	The line between the two halves. You may cross it freely; it only marks what is "your side".
Fast lanes	The two outer fields of the front rows are merged with the opponent's: one big shared field on each flank. It belongs to both players, and it's the quickest way across.

Where new Summons enter

On any free field of your **Guarded Zone**, as many as you can pay for.

Once per turn, you may instead place one in your Battle Zone 1 or 2, on a field **next to a Summon you already have** in that row.

Off the grid

Workers, Buildings, set Traps, Items and lasting Spells sit in your own areas beside the board, not on the fields. Destroyed cards go to your **Graveyard**; a card sent to the **Void** is out of the game for good.

What the first turns usually look like

Turns 1–2	Play a Worker each turn. Cast a cheap Summon or two into your Guarded Zone. They can't act yet, but Grace keeps them safe from attacks on the turn they arrive.
Turns 3–4	Move up into the Battle Zones. Set a Trap or two on fields the enemy will want to walk through. Keep a body at home in your Guarded Zone.
Later	Trade Summons in the middle, push through a fast lane, and once a Summon stands in the enemy's Guarded Zone, start hitting their Guardian.

CHAPTER 3

3 Energy and your turn

Energy pays for everything: casting cards, abilities, buying Treasures. It comes in nine elements plus Neutral.





A Worker: Northern Farmer makes 1 Light Energy every turn.

Reading a cost

A cost has a grey number and element symbols. The **grey number** is Neutral: any Energy can pay it. Each **element symbol** must be paid with Energy of that element.

> **So:** elemental Energy pays its own symbols *and* grey costs. Neutral Energy only pays grey costs. Owl Griffin (page 5) costs a grey 1 plus one Light: 2 Energy, at least one of it Light.

Where Energy comes from

- **Your Guardian**: 1 Neutral each turn.
- **Workers**: you may play **one Worker per turn**, for free. Each one makes Energy at the start of every turn. They're your economy, so play one early and often.

Saving Energy and the Treasure Chest

Unspent Energy carries over, but at the end of your turn you keep only as much as you have cards in your **Treasure Chest** (5 at the start); the rest is lost.

In your main phase you may **buy the top card** of your Treasure Chest: it costs as much Energy as there are cards left in it (5, then 4, then 3...). Treasures are strong, but every one you take also lowers how much Energy you can save.

A turn, phase by phase

1 Active
Your cards wake up (untap) and your Summons get their actions back. Workers and Guardian make Energy.

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2 Guardian
"At the start of your turn" effects: healing over time, Poison and the like.

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3 Draw
Draw 1 card.

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4 Tactic: your main phase
Do things in any order:
- play 1 Worker, and 1 Event
- cast Summons, Spells, Items... as Energy allows
- set Traps (free)
- move and attack with your Summons
- use abilities, buy from the Treasure Chest

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5 End
"Until end of turn" effects stop. Extra Energy is lost; hand down to 7 cards.

In the client, the phase bar shows where you are. Press **End Turn** when you're done.

CHAPTER 4

4 Reading a card

Summons are your units on the board. Here is everything on one.



1. **Element**: Light.
2. **Name**.
3. **Cost**: a grey 1 and one Light symbol, so 2 Energy.
4. **Type line**: card type (Summon), its kinds (Griffin) and element.
5. **Combat type**: how far it can attack (page 7).
6. **Rules text**: keywords and abilities. Text in brackets is a reminder of what a keyword does.
7. **Copy limit**: how many copies a deck may hold.
8. **Stats**, left to right:

3	0	1	0	0	0	
Life at 0 it dies	**Mana** for its own Spells	**Attack** physical damage	**Defense** blocks physical	**Magic** magic damage	**Resistance** blocks magic	**Movement** fields per turn

Owl Griffin: 3 Life, 1 Attack, Movement 2, and **Flying**. Point at anything in the client to read its full text.

The card types you'll meet first



Summon
Units on the board. Most of the game is about them.

Spell: Hex
One-shot effect, cast in your own main phase.

Spell: Quick
Can be cast any time you could answer something, even on your opponent's turn.

Trap
Set face down for free, paid for only when it goes off (page 8).

Worker
Makes Energy every turn. One per turn, free.

Later you'll also meet **Items** (Equipment for your Summons and other tools), lasting Spells (**Enchantments, Runes, Curses, Rituals**), **Buildings**, **Terrains** that change the ground, and two-sided **Events**.

CHAPTER 5

5 Moving your Summons

Every turn, each Summon can move once and attack once, in either order.

A Summon's turn

- **Move** once, up to its Movement.
- **Attack** once. Attacking **taps** it (turns it sideways): it's done acting for the turn, but it may still use its move.
- Some Summons have abilities marked with the **activate symbol**; using one also taps it.

Everything comes back at the start of your next turn.

The turn it arrives

A new Summon **can't move or attack** on the turn it enters, unless a keyword says otherwise (**Sprinting** lets it move, **Zealing** lets it move and act).

> **Grace.** To make up for it, a Summon that arrived this turn and hasn't done anything **can't be attacked** while it stands in your Guarded Zone. Grace lasts only for that turn, and only for attacks: Spells can still hit it.

How movement works

- Movement is **0 to 3** fields. A step up, down, left or right costs 1.
- A **diagonal step costs 2**.
- You can walk through your own Summons, but **enemies block the way**. You can't end on an occupied field.
- **Flying** Summons pass over enemies that don't fly.



A Summon with **Movement 2** (●). Gold fields are where it can go. The enemy (×) above blocks the straight path, so the field behind it is out of reach.

Reaching the enemy

Through the middle, a Movement 2 Summon needs a few turns to reach the far side. The **fast lanes** on the flanks save a turn, but your opponent knows that too.

CHAPTER 6

6 Combat

Fights are one blow at a time, like in a tactics game: the attacker strikes first, and the defender hits back only if it survives.

How an attack goes

1. **The attacker strikes.** Physical damage (Attack) is soaked up by the target's **Defense** first; whatever is left comes off its Life. Magic damage works the same way against **Resistance**.
2. **If the defender survives** and the attacker is within its range, it **counterattacks** automatically, the same way.
3. A defender that dies never hits back.

Defense and Resistance wear down. What they soak up is used up for the rest of the turn, so a second attack gets through more easily. They refill at the end of the turn.

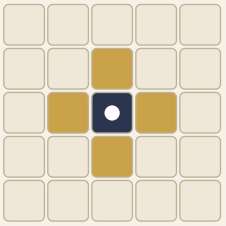
Example

1. Your Summon (Attack 4) attacks one with Life 3, Defense 2.
2. Defense soaks 2, so the target loses 2 Life. It survives with 1.
3. It strikes back with its own Attack against your Summon's Defense.
4. Your second Summon attacks it: its Defense is already spent, so every point hits Life.

> **Order matters.** Attack first with a Summon the target can't reach back, or soften it up before your important Summon goes in.

Range: the combat type

Distance counts like movement: a diagonal neighbour is **2** away.



Close Combat
Only the fields right next to it.



Ranged 2
Exactly 2 away, never next to it.



Bi Combat / Magic R2
Both: 1 or 2 away.

So an archer that shoots a Close Combat Summon from 2 fields away takes no counterattack. **Magic** types deal magic damage; Peaceful Summons can't attack.

Attacking the Guardian

- A Summon must stand **in the enemy's Guarded Zone** to attack their Guardian. Any combat type can do it from there.
- While the enemy has a **Guardprotect** Summon in their Guarded Zone, their Guardian can't be attacked: deal with the protector first.
- Guardians have no Defense, and never counterattack.

Your Guardian fights back

For **2 Energy**, your Guardian can attack an enemy Summon **in your own Guarded Zone**, using its Attack (or Magic). Nothing ever counterattacks a Guardian.

CHAPTER 7

7 Answers, Traps and keywords

You can react to what your opponent does, and they can react to you.

Responding: the Stack

When a card is cast, an ability used or an attack declared, it waits on the **Stack**, and the other player gets a chance to answer with a **Quick Spell** or a quick ability. The last thing added happens first.

Hex Spells, Summons and most other cards can only be played in your own main phase, when nothing else is waiting. The client asks you whenever you get a chance to respond; just pass if you don't want to.

Traps

- Setting a Trap is **free**, and it stays face down: your opponent only sees that something is there.
- You pay its cost only **when it goes off**, and only if you want it to.
- **Step Traps** guard one field: they go off when an enemy Summon moves onto it. Other Traps wait for a whole row, or for a certain action like an attack or a Spell.
- A Trap that harms the Summon setting it off only goes off for enemies, never for your own Summons.

> **Think of Traps as prevention.** They punish an opponent who walks in carelessly. They won't rescue a board you've already lost.

Common keywords

Manifest	Happens when the card enters play.
Demise	Happens when it goes to the graveyard.
Resonance	Happens every time its condition is met ("whenever...").
Perpetual	Always on, as long as the card is in play.
Onslaught	Happens after this Summon attacks.
Dominate	Happens when this Summon kills an enemy Summon in combat.
 **Flying**	Summons without Flying can't reach it in melee, and it passes over them when moving.
 **Guardprotect**	In your Guarded Zone, it shields your Guardian: attacks must go to it instead.
 **Swiftstrike**	When it attacks, the target can't counterattack.
 **Sprinting / Zealing**	Can move (Sprinting), or move and act (Zealing), on the turn it enters.
 **Poisoned**	Loses 1 Life at the start of each of its controller's turns, per Poison counter.

There are many more. The client shows each keyword's meaning when you point at it.

Tips for your first games

- Play a Worker every turn you can. Energy wins long games.
- Keep something in your Guarded Zone: an empty back row invites the enemy to walk in and hit your Guardian.
- Before you attack, check who can hit back, and who can reach you next turn.
- Defense wears down within a turn: two small attacks can beat one big defender.
- Don't rush every Treasure: each one lowers how much Energy you can save.
- The flanks are fast. Watch the fast lanes on both sides.